Earlier changes by the Modi government

2001-2004



In 2000, the National Curriculum Framework, 1988 was revised. During the **A.B. Vajpayee**-led BJP regime, books by Thapar, Sharma, Satish Chandra and Bipan Chandra were targeted for their purportedly 'anti-Hindu' bias. References to Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution, Aurangzeb and Shivaji in Satish Chandra's book, mentions of Tamil Brahmins eating meat and of Lord Mahavira in R.S. Sharma's book, and texts on Jats in books by Arjun Dev and Indira Arjun Dev, were deleted. Critics alleged that the BJP introduced mythology as history in textbooks to glorify Hindus and 'saffronise' the content.

2004-2014



In 2005, the UPA government led by **Manmohan Singh** revised the National Curriculum Framework 2000 and overhauled textbooks.

In 2008, controversy erupted when the NCERT replaced a book on the life of Gautam Buddha with Nehru's *Discovery of India* in the Hindi curriculum.



2017-2018

In the Class 12 political science textbook *Politics in India Since Independence,* the NCERT changed a heading of a passage describing the 2002 Gujarat riots from 'Anti-Muslim riots in Gujarat' to just 'Gujarat riots'. Also, GST and demonetisation and Beti Bachao were added as topics to books on economics, business studies, accountancy and political science.

2018-2019

In the history textbooks, the NCERT added content related to 'knowledge, traditions and practices of India', including portions on Vikram Samvat (the Hindu calendar), metallurgy, Shivaji, Maharana Pratap, the Paika revolt, Subhas Chandra Bose, Swami Vivekananda, Maharaja Ranjit Singh, Rani Avantibai Lodhi and Sri Aurobindo Ghose.

Content on caste conflicts, cricket history and the impact of colonial and capitalism on farmers was excised from the history textbook for Class 9.

phe suffered by Buddhism in India".

And if the BJP tried to saffronise education under Joshi, the subsequent Congress-led UPA government launched a new NCF in 2005 to "cleanse" textbooks of BJP-RSS influence. One of the biggest casualties under any BJP government—including in the states—has been Nehru. In the recent revision, too, two of his quotes have been removed in the Class 12 and 6 textbooks. The Congress, in contrast, has been guilty of erring on the other extreme. In 2008, the NCERT replaced *Buddha Charita*, a book on the life and teachings of Gautam Buddha, with the Hindi version of Nehru's *Discovery of India* in the Class 8 Hindi curriculum. In his book, *The Great Hindu Civilisation: Achievement, Neglect, Bias and the Way Forward*, diplomat-turned-politician Pavan K. Varma wrote: "There was the constant fear that the teaching of history should not become 'communal' by giving disproportionate space to the role of Hindu leaders in opposing Muslim rule. Subjects such as an investigation into the antiquity of ancient India were considered undesirable, as they may lead to Hindu 'glorification'. The unprecedented renaissance of the Bhakti period, lasting six centuries and producing some of the most exquisite devotional poetry, was eclipsed by the political chronologies of the Mughal empire."

The Yogi Adityanath-led BJP government in Uttar Pradesh has already announced that the state will be using the revised NCERT textbooks from this year. The state education ministers of non-BJP-ruled Rajasthan, West Bengal and Kerala, on the other hand, have firmly opposed the deletions. Their counterparts in Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Tamil Nadu and Odisha have said they are scrutinising the NCERT's changes. With the education minister as its president, the autonomy of the NCERT has often been called into question, and left it open to accusations of following the ruling party's agenda. While political parties vie with each other to fashion a history that is politically correct from their perspectives, it is the future of the students that is at stake. The onus now is on those involved in the preparation of the NCF to lay the foundation for textbooks which have an accurate and authentic representation of our past, sans religious or ideological prejudice. ■